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the Mangalsutra has been a game changer for Bvlgari in India. With Priyanka Chopra promoting it, they have ensured it will be a success with the Indian diaspora as well,” says Abhay Gupta, Founder and CEO of Luxury Connect, an advisory firm for luxury brands. Adds Pushpa Bector, Executive Director of DLF Retail: “Brands like Bvlgari are here to stay. They are innovating and the Bvlgari Mangalsutra has created quite a buzz.”

With the Mangalsutra, Bvlgari has re-established itself as a jewellery brand in India. Since jewellery is available in only one store and watches in 12 multi-brand stores, more Indians are familiar with Bvlgari watches than with the jewellery. “To be successful, we know we have to put jewellery first,” says Babin.

THE ROMAN HOUSE of Bvlgari has always been about design, quality and exceptional beauty when it comes to jewellery. Since its founding in 1884 in Rome

by Greek silversmith Sotirio Bvlgari, the brand quickly established itself as a maker of exquisite jewellery. “Jewellery is really the core DNA of the brand, together with Rome,” says Babin. The letter ‘V’ instead of ‘U’ in Bvlgari is a nod to its Roman heritage as ‘V’ was used in the Roman language in place of ‘U’.

Over the ensuing decades, some of the most famous celebrities and royalty from around the world came to the brand. In the 1950s and ’60s, when film studios were using Rome as the backdrop for many movies, celebrities such as Ingrid Bergman, Audrey Hepburn, Grace Kelly and others shopped at Bvlgari and the creations they purchased often showed up on the big screen.

Bvlgari then branched into women’s watches and, later, men’s watches, too. It then diversified into leather goods, fragrances and even hospitality, owning seven resorts across the globe with five more in the pipeline. So, will we see a Bvlgari resort in India? “India is a very competitive market. We need to find

something extraordinary so that like the other countries we operate in, we become the No. 1 here. In India it is difficult because the Oberoi and the Taj have set such high standards that are among the best in the world,” says Babin.

Under Babin’s leadership—he took over as CEO from Michael Burke in 2013 when Burke moved on as Louis Vuitton’s Managing Director—there has been an increased focus on watches. Bvlgari’s watches are renowned for their craftsmanship where it has successfully replicated its jewellery expertise. A prime example is the Serpenti, made with a Tubogas bracelet that curves around the wrist. The watch, made for women, has a serpent-shaped head that serves as the dial. While it started making watches for men in the mid-1970s, it’s only with the launch of the Octo collection a decade ago that it began to be noticed for its men’s watches.

“Everything we do will be more feminine than masculine. Being a jeweller, the foremost priority is to